



Cheetah

Acinonyx jubatus

The cheetah is built for speed. Its light, slender body and highly flexible spine help it to turn without losing its balance. Long muscular legs enable it to quickly reach strides of up to 23 ft (7 m). A small, short-muzzled head adds to its aerodynamics, and wide nostrils and large lungs enhance its breathing capacity. A large heart pumps blood to an optimal degree. Yet the cheetah is the least successful hunter among African cats—precisely because the adaptations that give it speed also restrict it in other ways. A short muzzle and small head lessen jaw strength. Its quick sprints can be sustained only for short distances, so it often fails to make a kill. High-speed bursts leave it overheated and in need of rest, so kills are easily stolen by other animals. For these reasons, cheetahs hunt mainly during the day to avoid stronger nocturnal predators.

Band of brothers

The cheetah's slight frame also makes it vulnerable to larger predators such as lions and hyenas; so solitary females with cubs are constantly on the lookout for danger. Males often band together for life, forming "coalitions" of 2 to 5 animals—sometimes related—which offers them greater protection. Once found throughout Asia and Africa, this species is now confined mainly to 25 African countries, with a critically endangered population of Asiatic cheetahs in Iran.

